



Subfinder Looks Simple. Your Recon Workflow Probably Isn't.

A practical guide to passive subdomain enumeration, and the details most tutorials quietly leave out

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Published August 30, 2026

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[Read here.](https://freedium-mirror.cfd/https://medium.com/@fatihaali093/subfinder-looks-simple-your-recon-workflow-probably-isnt-8c7317dc35df?sk=23fee8862a57a30868a3a74710aae407) (https://freedium-mirror.cfd/https://medium.com/@fatihaali093/subfinder-looks-simple-your-recon-workflow-probably-isnt-8c7317dc35df?sk=23fee8862a57a30868a3a74710aae407)

Subdomain enumeration is usually introduced with a command that looks almost too simple:

```
subfinder -d example.com
```

You get a list of domains.

Done.

Except it isn't.

That list is not the result.

It is the **beginning of reconnaissance**.

A subdomain such as:

```
api.example.com  
dev.example.com  
staging.example.com  
vpn.example.com  
old.example.com
```

can represent a completely different application, infrastructure stack, authentication boundary, cloud service, development environment, or forgotten asset.

And that is exactly where [Subfinder](https://github.com/projectdiscovery/subfinder) (https://github.com/projectdiscovery/subfinder) becomes interesting.

Subfinder is a passive subdomain discovery tool from ProjectDiscovery. It is designed specifically for discovering subdomains through passive online sources rather than directly probing the target. Its architecture is modular and optimized for speed, which makes it useful for penetration testing, bug bounty reconnaissance, and attack-surface discovery.

But there is a detail many beginner tutorials miss:

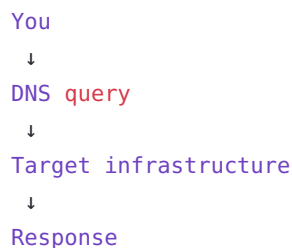
Subfinder doesn't tell you everything that exists. It tells you what its passive sources know about.

That distinction changes how you should use it.

1. First, Understand What Subfinder Actually Does

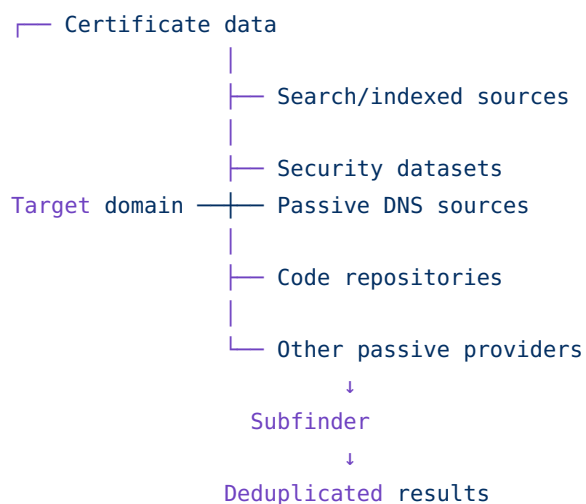
Before learning commands, understand the model.

Traditional discovery might look like:



Subfinder works differently.

Conceptually:



The important word is:

passive.

Subfinder is designed around passive sources, which means it can discover information without directly scanning the target's infrastructure. ProjectDiscovery specifically describes this passive model as useful for speed and lower-noise reconnaissance.

That makes it a very good **first step**.

It does not make it the **last step**.

2. What Is a Subdomain, Technically?

Start with:

```
example.com
```

Now:

```
api.example.com
```

is a subdomain of:

```
example.com
```

More examples:

```
dev.example.com  
mail.example.com  
vpn.example.com  
staging.example.com  
portal.example.com
```

But don't think of these as merely names.

Think of them as **potential application boundaries**.

For example:

```
www.example.com  
↓  
Marketing website
```

while:

```
api.example.com  
↓  
Backend API
```

and:

```
admin.example.com  
↓  
Administrative interface
```

and:

```
staging.example.com
↓
Development environment
```

The hostname tells you almost nothing by itself.

But the hostname can tell you **where to investigate next**.

3. Your First Subfinder Command

For an authorized target:

```
subfinder -d example.com
```

That's the basic workflow.

You provide a domain:

```
example.com
```

Subfinder queries its configured passive sources and returns discovered subdomains.

You can save the results:

```
subfinder -d example.com -o subdomains.txt
```

ProjectDiscovery documents `-d` for a single domain and `-o` for writing results to a file.

Your output might look like:

```
api.example.com
cdn.example.com
dev.example.com
mail.example.com
portal.example.com
staging.example.com
```

At this point, beginners often say:

"Great. I found six subdomains."

A security engineer asks:

"Why did these six appear?"

That question is much more valuable.

4. The Detail Most Tutorials Skip: Results Have Provenance

Suppose Subfinder gives you:

api.example.com

Where did it come from?

Maybe:

Certificate transparency

Maybe:

A passive DNS provider

Maybe:

A code repository

Maybe:

Another indexed source

This matters.

Two sources agreeing on the same hostname gives you more confidence than a single obscure source reporting it.

Subfinder can include source information when producing JSON output with `-cs`, which is particularly useful when you want to understand where a result originated.

For example:

```
subfinder -d example.com -json -cs -o results.jsonl
```

Now your data becomes more useful than a plain text list.

Instead of:

```
api.example.com
```

you can preserve metadata about the discovery.

This is important for serious recon because **a finding without provenance is harder to evaluate and reproduce.**

5. Why `-silent` Is More Important Than It Looks

Suppose you're building a pipeline.

You don't want banners, status messages, or other output mixed into your data.

Use:

```
subfinder -d example.com -silent
```

Now the output is focused on the discovered subdomains.

This becomes especially useful when piping the results into another tool.

For example:

```
subfinder -d example.com -silent | sort -u
```

Or:

```
subfinder -d example.com -silent > subdomains.txt
```

The larger lesson is:

CLI tools become much more powerful when their output is designed for another tool.

Subfinder supports stdin/stdout integration specifically so it can fit into reconnaissance workflows.

6. `-all` Does Not Mean "Everything on the Internet"

This is one of the most important details.

You will see:

```
subfinder -d example.com -all
```

The obvious interpretation is:

"Search absolutely everything."

Not quite.

`-all` tells Subfinder to use all available sources for enumeration, and ProjectDiscovery notes that this is slower.

Your actual results still depend on:

- which sources are available
- which sources require API keys
- source coverage
- source freshness
- provider limits
- the target's historical exposure
- whether the hostname was ever observed by those sources

So:

```
-all
```

does not equal:

```
complete visibility
```

It means:

```
maximum source coverage available to Subfinder in your configuration
```

That's a very different statement.

7. API Keys Change the Quality of Your Results

This is probably the most overlooked part of Subfinder.

You can install it and immediately run:

```
subfinder -d example.com
```

But many passive providers require API credentials for their data to be available.

ProjectDiscovery documents provider configuration through:

```
~/.config/subfinder/provider-config.yaml
```

and lists numerous providers that require API keys.

So if your results seem surprisingly small, don't immediately conclude:

"The target doesn't have many subdomains."

Instead ask:

"Which sources did my installation actually have access to?"

Run:

```
subfinder -ls
```

This lists the available sources.

That one command can explain a lot about your enumeration quality.

8. Source Coverage Is a Recon Variable

Imagine two researchers.

Researcher A:

```
Subfinder
↓
Minimal provider configuration
↓
17 results
```

Researcher B:

```
Subfinder
↓
Multiple configured passive providers
↓
64 results
```

The second researcher didn't necessarily discover a better target.

They had **better visibility**.

This distinction is critical:

```
Few results
≠
Few assets
```

Instead:

```
Few results
=
Few assets observed by your current sources
```

That is a much more accurate mental model.

9. Source Selection Can Be Useful

You can choose specific sources:

```
subfinder -d example.com -s crtsh
```

or multiple sources:

```
subfinder -d example.com -s crtsh,github
```

The exact source names available to you can be checked with:

```
subfinder -ls
```

ProjectDiscovery documents `-s` for selecting specific sources and `-es` for excluding sources.

Why would you do this?

Because sometimes you want to understand **where the data is coming from**.

For example:

```
Run 1:  
all configured sources  
Run 2:  
certificate-related source  
Run 3:  
specific intelligence provider
```

If a hostname only appears in one source, that's useful context.

10. The Most Important Limitation: Passive ≠ Current

Suppose Subfinder returns:

```
old-api.example.com
```

Does that mean the host is still alive?

No.

The hostname could have:

- been decommissioned
- changed IP addresses
- expired
- moved to another provider
- stopped serving HTTP
- become an orphaned DNS record

Passive data can be historical.

This is one of the most important things to remember:

Discovery is not validation.

Subfinder answers:

"What subdomains can I discover from passive sources?"

It does not automatically answer:

"Which of these are currently alive and serving an application?"

That requires another stage.

11. Discovery → Resolution → HTTP

A useful recon pipeline looks like:

```
Subfinder
  ↓
Subdomains
  ↓
DNS resolution
  ↓
Live hosts
  ↓
HTTP probing
  ↓
Technology identification
  ↓
Manual investigation
```

Think of each stage as reducing uncertainty.

Stage 1: Discovery

What names exist?

Stage 2: Resolution

Which names currently resolve?

Stage 3: HTTP probing

Which resolved names expose web services?

Stage 4: Fingerprinting

What technologies are running?

Stage 5: Security testing

What should I investigate further?

Subfinder is strongest at **Stage 1**.

Don't force it to do the job of every other tool.

12. Why Resolution Matters

Suppose your output contains:

```
dev.example.com
old.example.com
staging.example.com
api.example.com
```

You shouldn't assume all four are active.

A DNS check might reveal:

```
dev.example.com    → resolves
old.example.com    → NXDOMAIN
staging.example.com → resolves
api.example.com    → resolves
```

Now your dataset is more useful.

The distinction becomes:

```
Discovered
  ↓
Resolvable
```

Those are different states.

And later:

```
Resolvable  
↓  
HTTP service
```

is another state.

A mature recon workflow preserves these distinctions instead of flattening everything into a single "found/not found" list.

13. Wildcard DNS Can Create Confusion

Imagine a domain has wildcard DNS:

```
*.example.com → 203.0.113.10
```

Now random names such as:

```
abc123.example.com  
xyz999.example.com
```

may resolve even though those aren't necessarily real applications.

This can create false positives in active enumeration.

Subfinder includes wildcard elimination/resolution functionality, but you should still understand the underlying problem rather than blindly trusting a tool. ProjectDiscovery explicitly lists wildcard elimination among Subfinder's capabilities.

The lesson is broader:

DNS resolution does not automatically prove that a meaningful application exists at that hostname.

14. Recursive Enumeration Is Not the Same as "More Results"

Subfinder supports:

```
subfinder -recursive -d example.com
```

The `-recursive` option limits enumeration to sources that can handle recursive subdomain discovery.

This matters when you're dealing with deeper namespaces such as:

```
api.dev.example.com
internal.api.example.com
test.internal.example.com
```

But recursive discovery depends heavily on what the underlying sources know.

So don't think:

```
recursive = magical deep enumeration
```

Think:

```
recursive
=
use sources capable of discovering deeper subdomain relationships
```

Again, source capability matters.

15. `-dL` Is Where Subfinder Starts Becoming Interesting

Running one domain is useful:

```
subfinder -d example.com
```

But real organizations often have multiple domains.

You can provide a list:

```
subfinder -dL domains.txt
```

For example:

```
example.com
example.org
example.net
```

This turns Subfinder from a single-target utility into a scalable reconnaissance component.

ProjectDiscovery supports `-dL` for reading a list of domains.

This is particularly useful for authorized:

- bug bounty scopes
- enterprise asset inventories
- security assessments
- attack-surface management
- internal reconnaissance

16. Scope Management Becomes Critical at Scale

Here's something tutorials often fail to mention.

When you move from:

one domain

to:

hundreds **of** domains

your biggest problem may no longer be technical.

It becomes **scope**.

Suppose your organization owns:

company.com

but a discovered hostname points toward a third-party provider.

That doesn't automatically mean:

you may test the provider

Ownership of a hostname and authorization to test the infrastructure behind it are separate questions.

So before moving from passive discovery into active testing, establish:

```
What is in scope?  
Which domains?  
Which IPs?  
Which cloud resources?  
Which third parties?  
What testing is permitted?
```

Subfinder itself is passive, but what you do with its output can become active very quickly.

17. The Output Is a Dataset, Not a List

This is the mindset shift I want you to remember.

Don't save:

```
subdomains.txt
```

and forget about it.

Treat reconnaissance as structured data.

For each discovered hostname, think about:

```
Hostname  
Source  
First observed  
Last observed  
DNS status  
IP  
HTTP status  
Technology  
Environment  
Ownership  
Scope
```

For example:

```
api.example.com
↓
Source: certificate data
↓
DNS: resolves
↓
IP: 203.0.113.20
↓
HTTP: 200
↓
Technology: API gateway
↓
Environment: production
```

Now your recon has context.

18. JSON Output Is Underrated

Subfinder supports JSONL output:

```
subfinder -d example.com -oJ -o results.jsonl
```

The important distinction is:

Plain `text`

versus:

Structured `data`

Plain text is great for humans.

JSONL is much better for automation.

You can feed structured results into scripts, databases, pipelines, or later analysis.

ProjectDiscovery documents `-oJ` for JSON output and `-cs` for collecting source information in JSON mode.

If you're building a serious recon workflow, preserving metadata is often more valuable than preserving a beautiful terminal output.

19. Rate Limits Matter Even in Passive Recon

Passive does not mean:

```
unlimited
```

Your requests still go to third-party data providers.

Some providers have their own limits.

Subfinder supports global and provider-specific rate limiting through:

```
-rl
```

and:

```
-rls
```

according to its documented CLI options.

For example, the concept is:

```
Global rate limit
      +
Provider-specific limits
```

This matters because a reconnaissance workflow that works perfectly for one target can behave very differently when scaled to thousands of domains.

Good automation respects the infrastructure it depends on.

20. Timeouts Are Not Just Performance Flags

Subfinder also exposes:

```
-timeout
-max-time
```

These control how long the tool waits for operations and enumeration to complete.

Why does this matter?

Imagine a source is slow or temporarily unavailable.

Without thinking about timeouts, your entire pipeline may become dependent on the slowest provider.

A mature workflow treats:

```
Source failure
```

as:

```
partial data
```

rather than:

```
enumeration failed completely
```

That mindset becomes extremely important when you automate reconnaissance.

21. Don't Compare Two Runs Without Comparing Their Configuration

This is another subtle problem.

Imagine:

```
Monday:  
37 subdomains
```

and:

```
Friday:  
51 subdomains
```

Did the attack surface increase by 14?

Maybe.

But perhaps:

```
Monday:  
5 passive sources
```

while:

```
Friday:  
12 passive sources
```

The increase may be caused by **visibility**, not infrastructure.

For meaningful comparisons, record:

```
Tool version
Source configuration
API availability
Target scope
Timestamp
Output
```

This is a very simple habit that dramatically improves the quality of reconnaissance data.

22. Version Matters More Than People Think

Tools change.

Sources change.

Providers change.

APIs change.

Defaults change.

So when you document a recon result, record the Subfinder version:

```
subfinder -version
```

The CLI provides a version option, and the project recommends keeping the tool current.

This makes your work reproducible.

Imagine six months later someone asks:

"Why did we discover 200 assets in March but only 130 today?"

Without the configuration and version context, you're comparing numbers without knowing whether the measurement process changed.

23. One of the Best Subfinder Habits: Start Small

Don't begin every assessment with:


```
subfinder -d target.com -all
```

Start with:

```
subfinder -d target.com -silent
```

Understand the baseline.

Then:

```
subfinder -d target.com -all -silent
```

Compare the difference.

Then inspect sources.

Then validate the interesting results.

This teaches you something about your environment instead of turning reconnaissance into a button-clicking exercise.

24. A Simple Recon Workflow

For an authorized target, a clean workflow can look like this:

Step 1: Discover

```
subfinder -d example.com -silent -o subdomains.txt
```

Step 2: Remove obvious duplicates

```
sort -u subdomains.txt -o subdomains.txt
```

Step 3: Understand your sources

```
subfinder -ls
```

Step 4: Expand source coverage when appropriate

```
subfinder -d example.com -all -silent -o all-subdomains.txt
```

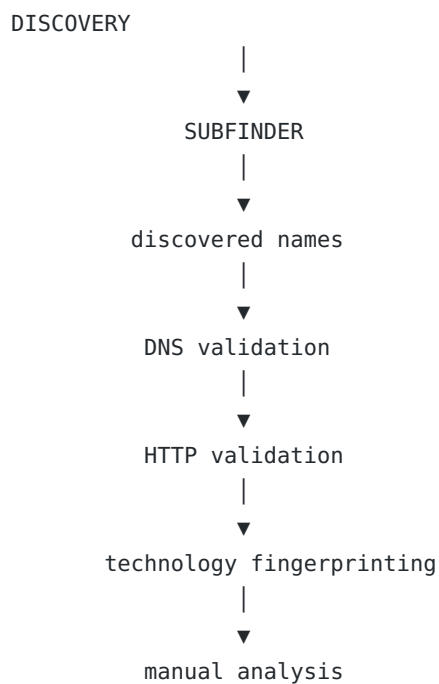
Step 5: Preserve structured output

```
subfinder -d example.com -json -cs -o results.jsonl
```

Step 6: Validate separately

Take the discovered hostnames into your DNS/HTTP validation stage.

The important architecture is:



Subfinder doesn't need to do everything.

It needs to do **one part extremely well**.

25. Where Subfinder Fits With Other Recon Tools

Subfinder becomes much more powerful when you understand its position in the ecosystem.

A simplified workflow might be:

```
Subfinder
  ↓
Subdomains
  ↓
httpx
  ↓
Live HTTP services
  ↓
Nuclei
  ↓
Potential security findings
```

Each tool has a different responsibility.

```
Subfinder → Discovery
httpx     → HTTP probing
Nuclei    → Template-based detection
```

That separation is important.

Don't ask:

"Why doesn't Subfinder tell me whether the server is vulnerable?"

Because that's not its job.

Good tooling follows the Unix philosophy:

Do one thing well, then compose it with other tools.

26. What Subfinder Will Not Tell You

This deserves its own section.

Subfinder will not automatically tell you:

```
This host is vulnerable.
```

It won't automatically tell you:

```
This application is running Apache.
```

It won't prove:

```
This server is currently online.
```

It won't prove:

```
This hostname belongs to infrastructure you are authorized to test.
```

It won't discover every possible subdomain.

It won't replace active DNS enumeration.

It won't replace certificate analysis.

It won't replace manual recon.

It won't replace understanding the target.

That's not a weakness.

It's a boundary.

And understanding tool boundaries is one of the fastest ways to become better at security engineering.

27. The Interesting Subdomain Isn't Always the Obvious One

Beginners often become excited by:

```
admin.example.com
```

Fair enough.

But don't ignore:

```
old.example.com  
dev.example.com  
staging.example.com  
uat.example.com  
internal.example.com  
legacy.example.com  
api-v2.example.com
```

Names such as these can reveal organizational history.

For example:

```
api.example.com  
api-v2.example.com  
api-v3.example.com
```

might tell you that multiple generations of an API exist.

Or:

```
old.example.com  
legacy.example.com
```

might indicate infrastructure that wasn't fully retired.

The hostname itself doesn't prove a security problem.

But it gives you a hypothesis:

There may be different security assumptions across different environments.

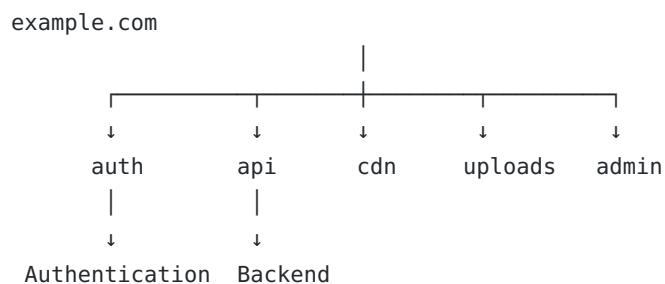
That's where good reconnaissance starts.

28. Subdomains Reveal Architecture

Imagine you discover:

```
auth.example.com  
api.example.com  
cdn.example.com  
uploads.example.com  
admin.example.com  
staging.example.com
```

You can start constructing an architecture hypothesis:



You haven't hacked anything.

You've simply converted DNS names into an architectural model.

That is the real value of reconnaissance.

29. The Detail Most People Miss: Historical Data Can Be Gold

A hostname that no longer resolves can still be interesting.

Why?

Because it tells you something existed.

For example:

```
old-api.example.com
```

might have disappeared from DNS.

But the historical existence of that hostname can reveal:

- naming conventions
- previous infrastructure
- old application versions
- cloud migrations
- development environments
- forgotten services

Again:

```
Not currently active
```

doesn't mean:

```
Not useful
```

for reconnaissance.

Historical information can help explain how an organization's attack surface evolved.

30. But Don't Turn Recon Into Hoarding

There is a temptation to collect everything.

Thousands of domains.

Millions of DNS records.

Endless passive sources.

Huge JSON files.

Then nobody knows what matters.

A better workflow is:

```
Discover
  ↓
Normalize
  ↓
Validate
  ↓
Prioritize
  ↓
Investigate
```

Prioritization is where the human becomes important.

For example:

```
api.example.com
```

might be high priority.

```
cdn.example.com
```

might be lower priority.

```
staging.example.com
```

might deserve attention because it suggests a non-production environment.

The hostname is a clue.

The surrounding context determines its value.

31. The Most Important Lesson: Subfinder Finds Names, Not Attack Surfaces

This distinction is worth repeating.

Suppose you discover:

50 subdomains

You do **not** necessarily have:

50 live systems

And you certainly don't automatically have:

50 vulnerabilities

The progression is:

```
50 discovered names
    ↓
40 resolve
    ↓
27 expose services
    ↓
12 contain applications
    ↓
5 are unusual
    ↓
2 deserve deeper investigation
```

That's reconnaissance maturity.

The goal isn't to maximize the number at the top.

The goal is to progressively reduce uncertainty until the important assets become obvious.

32. A Better Mental Model for Subfinder

Forget:

"Subfinder is a tool that finds subdomains."

That's technically correct but not very useful.

Think:

Subfinder is a passive visibility layer for discovering pieces of an organization's external naming and infrastructure footprint.

That changes how you use it.

You're no longer asking:

```
How many subdomains did I find?
```

You're asking:

```
What does the organization expose?  
What did it expose historically?  
Which sources know about it?  
Which assets are currently resolvable?  
Which ones lead to applications?  
Which ones deserve investigation?
```

Now Subfinder becomes part of a methodology rather than just another command.

33. The Workflow I Actually Recommend

For an authorized assessment, start with:

```
subfinder -d example.com -silent -o subdomains.txt
```

Then understand what you found.

Inspect available sources:

```
subfinder -ls
```

If broader coverage is appropriate:

```
subfinder -d example.com -all -silent -o subdomains-all.txt
```

Preserve source metadata when you need traceability:

```
subfinder -d example.com -json -cs -o subdomains.jsonl
```

For larger scopes:

```
subfinder -dL domains.txt -silent -o subdomains.txt
```

Then move the output into your next stage:

```
Subfinder
  ↓
DNS resolution
  ↓
HTTP probing
  ↓
Technology discovery
  ↓
Attack-surface classification
  ↓
Security testing
```

Don't skip the middle.

That's where a raw list becomes intelligence.

34. The Beginner Mistake That Took Me the Longest to Understand

When I first started learning reconnaissance, I thought the goal was:

Find as many subdomains as possible.

That sounds reasonable.

It isn't the complete picture.

The real goal is:

Build the most accurate picture of the target's externally observable attack surface.

Those are different objectives.

If I find 10,000 hostnames but don't know:

- which resolve
- which are alive

- which are in scope
- which are production
- which are historical
- which belong to third parties
- which expose applications

then I haven't necessarily performed good reconnaissance.

I've just generated a large text file.

The quality of recon is measured by **useful understanding**, not line count.

35. Subfinder's Real Power Is What Happens After It Finishes

The best Subfinder command is rarely the command you stare at in your terminal.

It's the command that feeds the next stage.

For example:

```
Subfinder
  ↓
subdomains.txt
  ↓
DNS validation
  ↓
resolved.txt
  ↓
HTTP probing
  ↓
live.txt
  ↓
technology discovery
  ↓
interesting-assets.txt
```

Now you have a pipeline.

And pipelines are where reconnaissance becomes scalable.

One domain becomes:

```
10 domains
```

Then:

100 domains

Then:

1,000 domains

The commands don't fundamentally change.

The methodology does.

36. The Details That Separate "I Ran Subfinder" From "I Know Subfinder"

If you remember nothing else, remember these:

1. Passive doesn't mean complete.

Subfinder depends on the visibility of its passive sources.

2. Results are not necessarily current.

Historical observations can appear in passive datasets.

3. API configuration affects coverage.

A minimal configuration can produce a very different dataset from a well-configured installation.

4. `-all` means all available sources, not all possible subdomains.

It also comes with a performance tradeoff.

5. Discovery isn't validation.

A discovered hostname isn't automatically live.

6. Resolution isn't application discovery.

A DNS record doesn't prove an application is running.

7. HTTP availability isn't vulnerability.

A `200 OK` response isn't a security finding.

8. Preserve provenance.

Knowing where a hostname came from makes your data much more useful.

9. Record configuration.

Version, sources, keys, timestamp, and scope matter when comparing results.

10. The output is intelligence, not a trophy.

The objective isn't the biggest list.

It's the best understanding of the attack surface.

Final Thought: The First Subdomain Is Rarely the Interesting Part

When Subfinder prints:

```
api.example.com
```

the interesting moment isn't the discovery itself.

It's what you ask next.

```
Who owns it?  
Does it resolve?  
What does it serve?  
Is it production or staging?  
What technologies are behind it?  
Why does this hostname exist?  
What other assets are related to it?
```

That's the difference between running a reconnaissance tool and actually doing reconnaissance.

Subfinder gives you visibility.

It doesn't give you conclusions.

And that's exactly why it's useful.

Because the goal of reconnaissance isn't to collect a mountain of hostnames.

It's to turn scattered public observations into a map:



Subfinder finds the names.

Your methodology determines whether those names become useful intelligence.

And that is the detail most tutorials leave out.